

Teaching Statement — Marcus Tobias Reyes

My approach to teaching is grounded in the conviction that quantitative methods become meaningful when students can trace them directly to real-world consequences. In every course I teach, I begin with a case: a dataset, a policy decision, a published finding that turned out to be wrong. Students engage with the problem before they learn the technique, which means they arrive at the methodology with a question already in hand.

At Emory I teach a graduate course in applied machine learning for public health. The course has no prerequisites beyond introductory biostatistics, and my students range from epidemiologists to health policy analysts to clinicians pursuing a master's degree. Designing for that range has sharpened my ability to explain the same idea at multiple levels of abstraction without losing rigor.

I have thought carefully about AI use policies in the classroom. I treat AI tools the way I treat calculators: useful for computation, dangerous as a substitute for reasoning. My syllabi include explicit guidance on what AI assistance is appropriate at each stage of an assignment, and I build in process checkpoints—annotated bibliographies, code walkthroughs, verbal defenses—that make the student's own thinking visible.

My teaching evaluations consistently place me in the top quartile of the school, and several students I have mentored have gone on to doctoral programs and research positions. I am committed to continuing to develop as an educator and to building curriculum that prepares students for a field that is changing rapidly.